Velocity alone is a terrible metric to measure how well a team can handle change and as a result is often a bone of contention when requirements are changing. If a team makes a commitment and starts a sprint, and then midway through the process the end goal moves, the team is set up to miss their commitment. You can reestimate or refactor your sprint goal, but in the grand scheme of things it will look like your team went through a patch of low productivity when perhaps they were more productive than ever.

Better metrics to use to track consistency through changing requirements are task volume and average estimates. The number of tasks that your team is able to accomplish in the face of change tempered by average estimates will give you a good picture of how consistently your team is completing its work. If your estimates consistently correlate to a few days of work and your task volume stays constant, you should be in good shape. If you see these trends along with an inconsistent velocity, it shows you that your team is doing great in the face of change.

Other metrics that help check team consistency while velocity is in flux are recidivism and lead time. Stable lead time and recidivism trends during periods of inconsistent velocity show that through changing commitments the time it takes to get tasks out the door and the health of your workflow remain solid. This is demonstrated in figure 10.12.

Figure 10.12. Velocity for this team is inconsistent, but total completed tasks are actually increasing. This is a typical indicator that the team completes tasks consistently despite changing commitments and/or requirements.